

CHAPTER THREE

The Inner Critic Goes to High School

— Priya —

The Critic showed up on the third day of high school.

I had been waiting for her. I had, all summer, been telling myself she was going to show up at some point. She had been quiet for most of eighth grade — I had gotten good, by then, at catching her early. I had a Post-it on my mirror. I had Sofia. I had Hannah. I had a journal habit. I had practiced for years.

She showed up Wednesday morning, third period, in geometry.

The geometry teacher, Mr. Lin, had given us a worksheet. Ten problems. Not hard — the kind of review problems teachers give the first week to find out who knows what. I worked through them. I got nine of them quickly. The tenth one I could not figure out.

I sat with the tenth one for two minutes.

The Critic showed up.

She said, in my head: *you cannot do this problem. You are in a class of older kids — some of these kids are sophomores. They are better at math than you are. They have already done this problem. They are going to look over at you and see you stuck on the tenth one. They are going to notice. They are going to think*

that freshman is slower. That is the impression you are going to make in the first week.

I caught her.

I said, in my head: that is the Critic. That is loud, not true. The tenth problem is hard. The tenth problem is supposed to be hard. The teacher gave us the tenth problem so we would have something hard to think about. Other kids in this room are also stuck on the tenth problem. I am not the only one.

The Critic, in my head, said: *yes you are.*

I said: *no I am not.*

The Critic said: *look up. Look at the other kids. You will see they have all finished.*

I looked up.

The girl next to me had finished — her worksheet was face-down on her desk. But the boy in front of me was still working on his. So was the girl across the aisle. So was the boy behind me, who I could hear erasing things.

I had been right. The Critic had been wrong. I was not the only one stuck on the tenth.

I went back to the problem.

I worked on it for another two minutes. I figured out the trick — I had been trying to use a formula I did not need to use. I put down the formula. I drew the triangle. I solved the problem.

I finished.

I sat for a second.

The Critic, in my head, said: *you are going to be slower than the rest of the kids in this class for the whole year. Today was the warning sign. You should drop down to regular geometry. You should not be in honors. You are going to fall behind.*

I caught her again.

I said: *that is the Critic. That is loud, not true. I finished the worksheet. I solved the tenth problem. I am in honors geometry because I am supposed to be in honors geometry. The placement was based on my eighth-grade scores. The school knows what it is doing. I am where I belong.*

The Critic said: *but you almost did not get the tenth one.*

I said: *almost is not the same as did not. I got it.*

The Critic, in my head, was a little quieter.

I sat for another minute. The bell was going to ring in five minutes. I had nothing to do.

I thought — *okay. I have just caught the Critic twice in one class. That is not a thing I have had to do in a long time. The Critic has not been this loud in maybe six months.*

I thought — *why is she louder now.*

I thought about it for a minute.

I thought — *oh.*

The reason she is louder now is that the room is new. The room is strangers. I am not in the cohort right now. The cohort kids who could catch the Critic for me — Sofia, Hannah, Marcus when I am with him — they are not in this room. The catching, in this room, has to be entirely mine. Nobody else is going to catch her. Nobody else even knows she exists.

The Critic, who has been getting quieter across the cohort's middle-school years because the cohort had been catching her with me, is louder again in the new room because the cohort is not here to help.

I am going to have to catch her by myself, more than I have had to in years.

This is — and I am writing this in my journal that night, in my room, after dinner — this is going to be the work of high

school. Catching her in rooms where the cohort is not. Catching her, by myself, in classes with strangers.

I have practiced. I have practiced for years. The practice was for exactly this.

But I am noticing — and I want to write this down — I am noticing that the practice in the cohort room is different from the real thing in a new room. The cohort room was practice. It was good practice. It was real practice. But it was with help. The high school class is going to be without help, most of the time, for me.

I have to get better at being my own help.

That is the freshman year work.

I have to become — and this is a thing I think Ms. Calloway has been preparing us for without quite naming it — I have to become my own call-somebody. The Inner Coach has been a thing I have known about since fourth grade. The Inner Coach has been, until now, backed up by the cohort. The Inner Coach in high school is going to be — most of the time, in most rooms — the only Coach in the room.

I can do it.

I have been doing it, in pieces, for five years.

I am going to get faster.

By May, when Ms. Calloway gives me back the sentence I wrote on the first day, I want it to have come true. The sentence I wrote was: *By the end of freshman year, I want to be true of me that the Inner Critic and I have a freshman-year relationship that is a step better than our eighth-grade relationship. Quieter. Faster catching. Less time wasted listening to her.*

I have nine months.

I am going to work on it every day, in every new class, with every new kid I meet, in every moment when she shows up.

The Critic is going to come along for the ride. She has been with me since I was nine. She will be with me for the rest of my life. The point is not to get rid of her. The point is to catch her faster.

This morning I caught her in geometry in under two minutes.

By May, I want to be catching her in thirty seconds. By the time I am thirty, I want to catch her before she finishes her first sentence.

That is the practice.

I am Priya. I am fourteen. The Critic is still here. The Critic is going to be loud in new rooms. The cohort is going to be in some of my rooms and not others. The catching is going to be mine.

I can do this. I am going to do this.

I just caught her again — five minutes ago, while writing this paragraph. She showed up at the part where I wrote *I can do this*. She said *you cannot, actually*. I said *that is the Critic*. *Loud, not true*. She got quiet.

The catching is happening, in real time, in my journal.

The journal is — I think — part of the toolkit too. Ms. Calloway told us, in seventh grade, that journals are not just diaries. Journals are practice space. The journal is where you practice catching things and putting them down. The catching practice can happen anywhere, but the journal is one of the easier places.

I am going to keep journaling. Every night. Or — well — every night I can. Most nights.

That is the freshman-year plan.

— Priya

(P.S. — *the cohort is not in every room. But the cohort is in this notebook. I can write to them in here, even when they are*

not next to me. That is also a thing.)